



of digital technologies or demand signals.

Q: What makes India so unique?

A: In other countries, while people are doing digital conversions, India is digitally native. And that's different. I can't really compare that to anywhere else because it gives us a unique ability to use that digital tech. We pilot things in India and the best example of that is how the team developed, in under six months, a way to configure an elevator—a small or an entry level elevator—where you can choose the aesthetics and order it online. The thinking was, you'd never be able to buy an elevator online because it's an industrial unit. We can do it now and we did it right here in India.

Q: Where does all this leave the US market for Otis?

A: When people think of American multinationals, there is a skew towards America. If you look at our business revenue base, a third comes from America, a third from Europe and a third from Asia. Of our 69,000 colleagues, 10,000 are in the US. So, we are truly global. We operate that way and understand the local needs. But the American market is a strong one for us. We were up almost in the high teens in terms of orders last year. It's coming off multiple years of strong constructions.

Probably the biggest demand we're seeing in the US is multi-family. Residential multi-family is huge and we're seeing that globally, but especially in the Americas, where offices have slowed down in terms of new construction, [but] multi-family

ON DISRUPTION & DIGITALISATION

I view them as an advantage. What's important is for you to disrupt versus waiting for others to enter your market. This is a very consolidated market and the reason for that is life and safety. I don't know customers who are going to say, 'Oh, I'll try a brand new entrant because they want to manufacture an elevator.' But that doesn't mean we can't be disrupted. So, the goal is, how do we disrupt ourselves before someone comes in and says, 'I can give you a software-as-a-service solution to do X.'

ON INDIA

There's probably no country I'm more optimistic about. Urbanisation rates are in the mid-30s. Our team has strong orders and we're the No. 1 player. We are pleased about every segment; that's why we've invested [here]

ON SAFETY

We're in the life-safety business. It's hazardous with people working at heights. We have 2 billion people a day who trust that our products will be safe, effective and reliable. You cannot look at a chart and say, 'Oh, we did 12 per cent better than last year.' The only answer is zero—zero fatalities, zero serious incidents

has picked up more than 20 per cent.

Q: How do you look at disruption and digitalisation today?

A: I view them as a competitive advantage. What's important is for you to disrupt versus waiting for others to enter your market. This is a very consolidated market and the reason for that is life and safety. I don't know customers who are going to say, 'Oh, I'll try a brand new entrant because they want to manufacture an elevator.' It doesn't work that way. But that doesn't mean we can't be disrupted. So, the goal is, how do we disrupt ourselves before someone comes in and says, 'I can give you a software-as-a-service solution to do X.' That means we re-invent and disrupt ourselves. There's a place for small businesses in this ecosystem and we believe independent service providers will always find small geographies and places to have a role. But as elevators become more digital and as your interactions become more frequent, customers are going to go with the original equipment manufacturers.

Q: This is the first time that Otis has had a woman in the corner office. What is your view on women in top positions today and how do you see the story unfolding?

A: It's also the first time Otis has had a non-Otis person in the corner office. We have to create an environment where women can thrive. There is an incredible amount of talent available in the world and I don't know why any company wouldn't want full access to that.

We are very focussed on that—not just on attracting talent, but retaining it. Our board is 40 per cent women and that's intentional. If you look at my leadership team, there are a significant amount of women and minorities. We have incredible diversity. But in terms of gender, we need to approach closer to parity, and we'll do that in the executive ranks. Our goal is by 2030, without increasing the executive ranks, to have 50 per cent women. **BT**

@krishnagopalan